

Assignment 3

Introduction to Linguistics 2

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Question 1:

Write a summary of “The Pronouns of Power and Solidarity” by R.Brown and A.Gilman in at least 1000 words. In particular, highlight the nuances in the difference between T and V pronouns.

Social hierarchy, power structures, familial relationships, intimate connections and even sarcasm in European languages is supplemented by the use of two types of pronouns.

Historically, Latin used the singular tu and plural vos. However, as there were two Holy Roman Emperors, who would rule the Eastern and Western parts of the empire, the vos began to be used to refer to THEM, in order to show this implicit plurality of emperor. Later, the vos began to be used for other powerful figures. It eventually became a marker of social hierarchy.

Thus, European languages were left with the:

T: showing a more familial or intimate relation between people on the same rung of the social ladder.

V: to show a more distant relation, something that is hindered by the hierarchical nature of power.

Power is not only wealth, it is also gender, lineage, age, physical strength, religious piety, and one's social circle.

It is important to understand that this power is not always reciprocal. The one who's higher up the social ladder, says T and receives V:

God to his Angels, masters to their servants, nobleman towards commoners and parents to their children.

Hence, there can be two types of usages of T/V:

A non-reciprocal usage:

Superior -> T -> Inferior -> V -> Superior

Or a reciprocal usage:

A mutual T (same social status and close) or a mutual V (same social status and distant).

When it came to people belonging to the same social group, the upper classes exchange the mutual V as a sign of their 'good breeding', while the use of the mutual T was seen as a sign of poor manners, often associated with someone belonging to the lower classes.

Hence, the T is usually used to signal a close and intimate relation between people, while the V denotes formality amongst relations.

However, signaling solidarity isn't the only purpose of the T, and showing respect isn't the only usage of V. Sometimes, it is used for quite the opposite.

In Act 4 of Marlowe's play, Tamburlaine uses a mocking 'you' (V) for the captive Turkish emperor Bajazeth.

This 'you' is not a sign of respect or humility. It is used by Tamburlaine to remind the starving emperor of the power he has now lost.

More recently, In Germany in the 1940s, a prostitute and her client said 'du' when they met and while they were together, then resumed the mutually distant 'Sie' afterwards.

Here, in the first example, the 'you' is in opposition to the actual power dynamic, while in the second, the du doesn't truly signify a close personal relation amongst the prostitute and her client.

Hence, T isn't only used for connotating 'You and I have a close personal relationship', it also shows a temporary alliance or can be used to insult and demean someone, as can be seen from the famous Shakespearean:

"Don't thou thou me!" or the "Taunt him with the license of ink, if thou thou'st him thrice, it shall not be amiss."

This dynamic of T and V is by no means common across languages. French uses its T to refer to fellowship and camaraderie based on shared experiences (a possible consequence brought on by the French revolution). German on the other hand reserves its T for familial relations based on kinship. Italians merge the use of T from German and French, supplementing the familial relations of the German T with the camaraderie represented by the French T.

Earlier, the distribution of power was associated with the feudal system, which linked a person's status with their birth and lineage.

As social mobility accompanied revolutions, a semantic shift was observed in Europe. After the French Revolution, the Committee for Public Safety condemned the use of vous as a feudal remnant and ordered a universal reciprocal T. This transformed all address to the neutral 'citoyen' and the mutual 'tu' (Robespierre even addressed the president of the assembly as 'tu'). However, in later years, solidarity declined and the differences of power which had always existed everywhere were expressed once more.

Even in the absence of discriminating pronouns, there exist non-reciprocal forms of address.

In America, it is acceptable for a father to call his children by their first names. However, it is usually unacceptable for the children to reciprocate the same with their father.

In the American South, there are no pronouns to signal the racial segregation, yet it is manifested via forms of address:

A white man will call a black person by his or her first name. However, the latter is expected to call the former as Mr./ Mrs./ Miss. plus their last name.

This shows that though English has lost its T/V distinction, it still retains a way to project social differences via forms of address.

A person's pronoun style also correlates with their political ideology.

In a study conducted on French students, (all belonging to upper middle class professional families in order to reduce distinctions based on other social factors, and gauge social differences along with their impacts within the same class)

radical individuals broadly applied the T, as a way to extend solidarity and remove social barriers; while the conservatives favored a more hierarchical V.

But, if there needs to be a change from V to T amongst two individuals, how is that brought about? Who initiates this change in the dynamic?

It is initiated by the more powerful member of the two. Hence, as social construct demands, the T must be offered by:

The nobleman to the commoner, the boss to the employee, the older to the younger, the adult to the child, and the master to the servant.

It signifies a person of higher social status 'stepping down' and bringing themselves to the level of the one with lower social status; 'demeaning' themselves to offer camaraderie and an equal status to the latter.

Hence, even when it comes to solidarity and equality, power semantics still dictate who is allowed to initiate this change in a relation, and who has to simply wait passively for this change to occur.

Question 2:

Consider the categories of humorous FTAs from "Humorous face-threatening acts: Humor as strategy" by Anat Zaidman: on-record, with/without redressive action (specifically positive/negative face within the frame of reference of positive/negative politeness), and off-record. Which type of humorous FTAs do you think would be used when

- Both speaker and hearer address each other with T

When both the speaker and the listener address each other as T, it points to a familiarity and closeness between them, placing them on the same social rank.

Hence, a **bald-on-record FTA**, which is concise, unambiguous and to the point, may be used. This strategy may be selected to minimize the face threat when there is consent between S and H as to the legitimacy of this act, and when the danger to H's face is very small.

Inside jokes can also help in this situation, hinting at a shared past to improve the closeness of the relationship.

- **The speaker addresses the hearer with T and the hearer addresses the speaker with V**

This gives the speaker the ability to use multiple types of FTA. The speaker is in a socially higher position. The H cannot rebut or get offended without incurring the social cost of displeasing a superior. Hence, such an S can use: **redressed, humorous, off-record or bald-on-record FTA's** without stressing too much about the consequences.

- **The speaker addresses the hearer with V and the hearer addresses the speaker with T**

The best FTA that the speaker can use in this situation is **self-deprecating humor**. This is because the pronoun relationship shows that the speaker is at a social disadvantage. He/she cannot crack a joke without the risk of offending the H, who has a social advantage. Self-mockery and denigration are one of the best FTAs for this situation as they have minimal social risks.

- **Both speaker and hearer address each other with V**

In this, both S and H have the similar social positions. However, they do not have an intimate relationship and cannot risk hurting the other person's feelings.

Hence an **off-record FTA** is the best option as if any party is hurt during the conversation, the other can simply wave it off as 'just a joke'

Question 3:

Consider the "Figure 2" about social dyads in the article "The Pronouns of Power and Solidarity" by R. Brown and A. Gilman. Explain whether the same relationships are seen in your mother tongue by drawing out the same figures for your mother tongue.

T → तुम/तू

V → आप

hierarchy : आप
तुम
तू

Father
तुम/तू ↓ ↑ आप
Child

Mother
तुम/तू ↓ ↑ तुम
Child

Officer
तुम ↓ ↑ आप
Soldier

Employer
तुम ↓ ↑ आप
Employee

Customer
आप / तुम ↓ ↑ आप
Waiter

Master
तू ↓ ↑ आप
Servant

Elder Brother
तू/तुम ↓ ↑ आप
Younger Brother

As we can see, in **Hindi**, the form of T used for the subordinate differs depending upon the type of employment and the difference between the social classes of the employer and employee.

Hence a master can refer to his servant as 'tu', but a corporate employer refers to his employee as 'tun'. One thing to note

(which may differ depending on social circle, but is quite prevalent in mine)

is that children usually rely on the formal 'aap' to refer to their father, whilst opting for a more informal 'tum' for their mothers, perhaps reflecting the emphasis put on a mother's role as more of a nurturer, than an enforcer of discipline, in Indian society.

Question 4:

English used to have T and V pronouns, but they aren't used anymore. How and why did this shift happen, and how did this influence politeness in the language? Explain in at least 1000 words.

English used to have a distinction between thee: singular (T) and ye/you: plural (V). 'ye' was the second person plural and 'thou' the singular. 'You' was originally the accusative of 'ye', but in time it also became the nominative plural and ultimately ousted 'thou' as the usual singular.

The T was usually used to signal a close and intimate relation between people, while the V denoted formality amongst relations.

However, signaling solidarity wasn't the only purpose of the T, and showing respect was not the only usage of V. Sometimes, it is used for quite the opposite.

In Act 4 of Marlowe's play, Tamburlaine uses a mocking 'you' (V) for the captive Turkish emperor Bajazeth.

TAMBURLAINE: Here Turk, wilt thou have a clean trencher?

BAJAZETH: Ay, tyrant, and more meat.

TAMBURLAINE: Soft, Sir, you must be dietee; too much eating will make you surfeit.

This 'you' is not a sign of respect or humility. It is used by Tamburlaine to remind the starving emperor of the power he has now lost.

Jespersen believed that English 'thou' and 'you' were more often shifted to express mood and tone as compared to the pronouns of continental languages.

Examples of the 'thou' of contempt being used can be seen from the famous Shakespearean:

"Don't thou thou me!" or the "Taunt him with the license of ink, if thou thou'st him thrice, it shall not be amiss." or the "All that he did, was at thy instigation, thou viper; for I thou thee, thou traitor."

In Shakespeare's plays there are expressive meanings that are dependent on power usage.

The play *Two Gentlemen of Verona* is concerned with the Renaissance ideal of friendship and provides especially clear expressions of solidarity.

Proteus and Valentine, the two gentlemen, initially exchange 'thou', but when they touch on the subject of love, on which they disagree, their address changes to the 'you' of estrangement.

In English drama of the past, T and V were marvelously sensitive to feelings of approach and withdrawal.

However, in French, German and Italian today this use seems to be very uncommon. The T, once extended, is almost never taken back for the reason that it would mean the complete withdrawal of esteem.

In the seventeenth century 'thou' and 'you' became explicitly involved in social controversy. The Religious Society of Friends (or Quakers) was founded in the middle of this century by George Fox, promoting the use of Plain Speech, which entailed saying 'thou' to everyone.

George Fox explained the practice in these words:

'Moreover, when the Lord sent me forth into the world, He forbade me to put off my hat to any, high or low; and I was required to Thee and Thou all men and women, without any respect to rich or poor, great or small'

Fox argued that T to one and V to many was the natural and logical form of address in all languages, citing Latin, Hebrew, Greek, Arabic, Syriac, Egyptian, French, and Italian to support his claim. He suggested that the Pope, in his vanity, introduced the corrupt and illogical practice of saying V to one person. Farnsworth, another member of the Society, argued that Christian scriptures showed that God and Adam and God and Moses also said and receive the singular T.

The Friends' reasons for using the mutual T was to remove a hierarchical order based on birth, replacing it with camaraderie based on shared experiences amongst the population.

However, they always remained a minority, and society as a whole was antagonized by their violations of decorum.

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In America and in Europe, there are forms of nonreciprocal address for all the dyads of asymmetrical power; customer and waiter, teacher and student, father and son, employer and employee.

What happens when there's a status change? In the example given by the author,

Award of the doctoral degree, for instance, transforms a student into a colleague and, among American academics, the familiar first name is normal.

The fledgling academic may find it difficult to call his former teachers by their first names. Although these teachers may be young and affable, they have had a very real power over him for several years and it will feel presumptuous to deny this all at once with a new mode of address. English allows him a respite.

He can avoid any term of address, staying with the uncommitted 'you', until he and his addressees have got used to the new state of things. This linguistic rite of passage has, for English speakers, a waiting room in which to gather up courage.

So, does the removal of the 'V' in English affect the politeness of the language? Not quite. Though in the previous example, it allows a person to better be able to handle a social change (both upwards and downwards), it is not very effective due to the abundance of non - reciprocal forms of address that reinforce the social division.

The modern direction of change in pronoun usage expresses a will to extend the solidary ethic to everyone. It aims to move from a rigid social hierarchy to one that allows for upwards mobility.

The apparent decline of expressive shifts between T and V, as in the Shakesporean example, is more difficult to interpret.

Though this could have a positive connotation: the apparent decline in seclusion of people belonging to a different social group based on class, race etc., it could also signal a more superficial understanding of extending social capital to the marginalized,

mistakenly believing that the solidarity extended by those of a higher social position to those at a lower rung of the ladder, cannot be withdrawn and is hence a sign of security.